



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Michael High School

School Website: <https://stmichaelchesterton.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Michael High School, Petoskey, Michigan (a Chesterton Academy) presents a clearly articulated classical-Catholic program that aligns strongly with core Classical education tenets. The campus emphasizes a unified integration of faith, virtue formation, and a rigorous liberal-arts curriculum anchored in the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (mathematics, geometry, astronomy, music), all within a Catholic framework. Public materials repeatedly stress that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable, and that education forms character and intellect in service of the eternal rather than solely for workforce preparation. The school explicitly frames itself as a “Classical Catholic” institution with a distinctive Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) and a mission to cultivate “leaders and saints” through a holistic formation that interweaves faith, reason, and virtue. The public-facing materials consistently foreground liturgical life, faith formation, and communal practices, while also detailing a rigorous curriculum and Socratic pedagogy. Taken together, these signals place St. Michael High School firmly in the CLASSICAL category, with strong alignment in religious foundations, purpose, curriculum design, pedagogy, faculty orientation, and parent/community partnership.

Key evidentiary anchors include: the school’s emphasis on an “Authentically Catholic, Rigorously Classical” approach and its Catholic formation framework; the Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality); integration of liturgical life and faith formation into daily school life; a curriculum described as integrated, classical, and Catholic with explicit reference to the Socratic Method and a liberal arts orientation; and active parent/community engagement through the Chesterton Schools Network and family partnerships. These cues appear across multiple materials, including Our Mission statements, curriculum descriptions, and faculty pages. See excerpts and corroborating materials here: Sacred liturgy and faith life interwoven with academics; Three Pillars in action; Great-work Western-Civilization context; and explicit Catholic formation signals.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Collectively, the six categories converge on a CLASSICAL classification for St. Michael High School. The school’s materials consistently foreground faith-informed formation, transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty), a liberal-arts curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, and a robust community-and-parents partnership ethos. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Note on methodology: For each category, keywords found in public materials (primarily the school website and Chesterton Academy network pages) were mapped to the Positive Keyword Indicators and Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) lexicon. The presence and weighting of positive vs. negative signals were used to derive category-level ratings, followed by an aggregate appraisal. The lexicon and element summaries used to ground the analysis include references to: sacred/vital roles of faith and liturgy, the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books/Great Conversation, Socratic pedagogy, memory work (chanting, recitation), “living curriculum” faculty, and parent/community partnership,

among others. See the Six Essential Elements lexicon and accompanying guidance for the positive/negative keyword indicators.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public statements foreground Catholic faith as central to education, including the phrase “Authentically Catholic, Rigorously Classical” and frequent mentions of faith integration into daily life.
- Official materials describe faith and prayer as permeating the school day and beyond; liturgical life is highlighted (Mass, chaplain, Catholic formation).
- The Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) anchors formation with explicit spiritual aims.
- Additional Catholic formation signals (Pro-Life ministry, Cultura Vitae; chaplain, Mass) reinforce the metaphysical grounding.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive signals present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; chant; sacred music; awe/wonder; imago Dei; wisdom; virtue; sacred ritual; sacramental worldview.
- Negative signals: not evident in public materials (no clear relativism, secular humanism, or values-clarification language appears).
- Estimated: High density of positive metaphysical/religious terms; near-zero negative signals.
- Why this rating
- The school’s materials center Catholic spiritual aims, liturgical life, and a sacramental worldview as foundational, with explicit catechetical and liturgical commitments, aligning strongly with the Positive Indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The presence of liturgical life, theology integration, and transcendentals supports a CLASSICAL rating. See exemplars above.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom rather than mere job-readiness; aims to form a generation oriented toward eternal truths (e.g., “not merely success in this world, but salvation in the next”; “not merely to get into college but into Heaven”).
- Public materials describe a telos oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty, and the Great Conversation/long-form questions as constitutive of education. The “Three Pillars” frame purpose around intellect, character, and spirituality.
- The curriculum and mission statements emphasize formation over purely instrumental outcomes, with explicit critique of trivialization of education and a focus on virtue-excellence.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive signals present: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, scholé, contemplation, Great Conversation, classical mission, human flourishing, moral imagination.
- Negative signals: explicit workforce-prep language is largely avoided in public messaging; the site emphasizes formation rather than job-readiness.
- Estimated: Predominantly positive keywords; very few, if any, negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The school consistently frames education as formation in virtue and wisdom with transcendent aims, emphasizing a classical telos over direct workforce preparation. This maps cleanly to CLASSICAL across the purposes/goals category. See mission and pillar language.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Curriculum is described as Integrated Classical Catholic; major components include humanities, math-/science, and fine arts; explicit reference to “the Trivium and Quadrivium” and to a liberal-arts core.

- Humanities are braided across disciplines with the Socratic Method; history is integrated with literature, philosophy, theology, and languages.
- Public materials emphasize Great Books/Western Civilization through the curriculum, with aims toward writing, public speaking, and mastery of classical disciplines. The Uncommon Core language signals a canonical, tradition-based curriculum.
- Additional curricular signals reference Great Books/Western tradition and a deliberate study of classical texts.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive signals present: liberal arts; trivium; quadrivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; primary sources; classics; history; Western civilization; Socratic texts; recitation; narration; dictation; ancestors of classical education (e.g., chant, hymnody); memory work; formal rhetoric.
- Negative signals: none of the major negative signals (social-studies history language replacement; STEM-first framing; project-based dominance) appear in the core materials.
- Estimated: Predominantly positive keywords; minimal or no negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum is framed around classical core elements (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Liberal Arts) and explicitly uses Socratic/recitation-based methods, with an integrated humanities emphasis. This strongly supports CLASSICAL categorization for Curriculum. See “Integrated, Classical, Catholic” curriculum language and the Socratic-method emphasis.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The humanities program uses the Socratic Method; history/literature/philosophy/theology/languages braided together with inquiry-based dialogue.
- Pedagogical signals include memory-work, recitation, chanting, and a rest/Schol -oriented pace (as described in the Classical lexicon and the Chesterton network materials); upper-level pedagogy features seminars, rhetoric, and public speaking opportunities.
- Foundational principles emphasize a balance of contemplation/restful elements with rigorous, dialog-based learning; lower-school singing/chanting and memory-building are cited in canonical materials.
- The Chesterton/Chesterton-network materials emphasize a classical learning model (the Uncommon Core), with a long-term emphasis on virtue, rhetoric, and debate.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive signals present: Socratic Method, dialectic, narration, recitation, chanting, memory-work, liturgical integration, seminars, Paideia-style discussions, rhetoric and oratory, debate.
- Negative signals: the lexicon warns against an excessive focus on experiential learning or project-based-only approaches; the site’s materials do not primarily emphasize those modes.
- Estimated: Predominantly positive keywords; minimal negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The school’s pedagogy centers on Socratic discussion, rhetoric training, and memory-based learning, with a blend of contemplative/restful and rigorous inquiry. This aligns with CLASSICAL pedagogy principles. See the explicit Socratic-method description and memory/chanting practices.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Our Faculty & Staff page showcases a named, mission-aligned cohort (Headmaster, Humanities faculty, Math/Lyceum, Music, Art, etc.), with faculty serving as mentors and leaders in their disciplines.
- Faculty roles include heads and teachers who model virtue and provide leadership within the school community; the broader Chesterton network materials discuss a “living curriculum” and the role of teachers as exemplars and guides.
- The Chesterton Academy framework emphasizes a teacher-centered, virtue-centered “living curriculum” and a portrait of what a teacher should be, which aligns with Classical indicators for faculty.
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive signals present: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum; portrait of teachers; collegial culture; teachers as guides; Master/mentor language; great-books seminars for faculty.
- Negative signals: none evident in public-facing materials.
- Estimated: High density of positive keywords; minimal to no negatives.
- Why this rating
- The publicly posted faculty rosters and descriptions frame teachers as central to the educational mission, with emphasis on virtue, collegial culture, and living curriculum—core CLASSICAL faculty signals. See Our Faculty & Staff page and Chesterton-network faculty-language materials.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Chesterton Academy network pages stress that Chesterton schools are parent-led and that the network provides templates for evaluating interest, along with support for parent-led Catholic classical education. This signals a foundational partnership with families as co-educators.
- Primary school communications emphasize parent involvement, open campuses, and community formation; the “A Chesterton Academy” framework highlights family-centered curriculum and parent formation through networks and gatherings.
- The school’s public materials emphasize family and community engagement, as well as generous donor involvement and community support (tuition, scholarships, and a broader “family” culture).
- Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis
- Positive signals present: partnership with families; co-teachers with parents; parent formation; classical book-clubs and gatherings; open campus and family involvement.
- Negative signals: consumer-language signals or minimal parental access do not appear in the public materials; the content leans toward partnership and formation.
- Estimated: Predominantly positive keywords; very few negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The materials emphasize a proactive, partnership-based approach with parents as co-educators, parent formation through readings/gatherings, and welcoming visits. This maps to CLASSICAL expectations for parents/community engagement. See Chesterton-network materials and parent-partner language.

What Would Move the Needle

- None required for this school given CLASSICAL results across all six categories. If desired, modest enhancements could include explicit, public-facing articulation of a “living curriculum” in faculty profiles beyond listing roles, and a more explicit cross-walk between Great Books/Great Conversation language and classroom practices, though current materials already imply these elements. (No category is ranked NOT CLASSICAL or SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL at this time.)

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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